

2026 EDITION

The BCBA Exam Survival Guide

What to study, in what order, and how to check your readiness before test day.

Written to the BACB BCBA Test Content Outline (6th ed.), the outline in effect for exams administered from January 2025 onward.

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How to use this guide

Read the introduction and Chapter 1 first, even if your exam is weeks away. They tell you which edition your study materials need to match. Then build your schedule from Chapter 2 and use Chapters 3 through 5 as you go.

What the 2026 BCBA exam is

The BCBA examination is built from the Behavior Analyst Certification Board's BCBA Test Content Outline (6th ed.). Every exam administered since January 2025 draws its questions from the 104 tasks in that outline, organized into nine domains lettered A through I.

The exam has 185 multiple-choice questions: 175 that count toward your score and 10 unscored pilot questions that the BACB is testing for future forms. You cannot tell which are which, so treat every question as scored. You have four hours.

Check your materials before you study

A lot of study material still on the market was written to the 5th Edition Task List, which the 6th Edition outline replaced. The quickest way to tell: the 5th Edition gave Behavior-Change Procedures the single largest share, about a fifth of the exam, and called Section A "Philosophical Underpinnings." If your notes, flashcards, or question bank use those labels and weights, they are describing an exam you will not sit.

Two edition tells

6th Edition materials say "Test Content Outline," not "Task List," and name Domain A "Behaviorism and Philosophical Foundations" and Domain E "Ethical and Professional Issues."

What this guide gives you

- The 6th Edition domains with task counts, question counts, and exam weights (Chapter 1).
- A 12-week schedule that assigns each domain to a week (Chapter 2).
- The concepts and decision rules that show up across domains (Chapter 3).
- Pacing, question analysis, and anxiety management for a four-hour exam (Chapter 4).
- Study and exam-day mistakes, each paired with what to do instead (Chapter 5).
- Official resources and a 30-day action plan (Chapter 6).

The 6th Edition Test Content Outline

The table below is the BACB's own breakdown. "Tasks" is how many numbered statements the domain contains; "Questions" is how many scored items the exam draws from that domain.

Domain	Tasks	Questions	% of exam
A. Behaviorism and Philosophical Foundations	5	8	5%
B. Concepts and Principles	24	24	14%
C. Measurement, Data Display, and Interpretation	12	21	12%
D. Experimental Design	9	13	7%
E. Ethical and Professional Issues	12	22	13%
F. Behavior Assessment	8	23	13%
G. Behavior-Change Procedures	19	25	14%
H. Selecting and Implementing Interventions	8	20	11%
I. Personnel Supervision and Management	7	19	11%
Total scored questions	104	175	100%

Plus 10 unscored pilot questions, for 185 questions on the day.

How the weight is spread

No domain dominates. The two largest, Behavior-Change Procedures (G) and Concepts and Principles (B), are 14% each. Behavior Assessment (F) and Ethical and Professional Issues (E) are 13% each. Six of the nine domains sit between 11% and 14%, so skipping any one of them costs you a meaningful share of the exam.

The two smallest domains, Behaviorism and Philosophical Foundations (A, 5%) and Experimental Design (D, 7%), together still account for 21 scored questions.

Questions per task: where study time pays back fastest

Divide each domain's questions by its tasks and the outline tells you something the percentages alone do not. Behavior Assessment has 8 tasks carrying 23 questions, about three questions per task. Personnel Supervision and Management (7 tasks, 19 questions) and Selecting and Implementing Interventions (8 tasks, 20 questions) are close behind. Concepts and Principles has 24 tasks for 24 questions: the most to learn per point on the exam.

That does not mean you skip Domain B. It means domains F, H, and I reward depth on a small number of tasks, while Domain B rewards breadth and precise definitions. Plan your time accordingly.

What changed from the 5th Edition

- The document is now a Test Content Outline, not a Task List, and it grew from 92 items to 104 tasks.
- Domain A was renamed Behaviorism and Philosophical Foundations. Domain E was renamed Ethical and Professional Issues.
- Domain E now includes explicit tasks on cultural humility (E.9), culturally responsive and inclusive service (E.10), and identifying personal biases (E.11). Cultural variables also appear in Behavior Assessment (F.2) and Supervision (I.3, I.5).
- Weight moved away from Behavior-Change Procedures and toward Assessment, Interventions, and Supervision. Supervision alone is now 11% of the exam.
- Domain B added items on emergent relations and generative performance (B.21), behavioral momentum (B.22), the matching law (B.23), and imitation versus observational learning (B.24).

Do this today

Download the BCBA Test Content Outline (6th ed.) from bacb.com and keep it open while you study. Every practice question you miss should map back to a numbered task on that list.

A 12-week study schedule by domain

Twelve weeks is enough for a candidate who has finished coursework and can study about ten hours a week. If you have less time, compress the foundation weeks; do not compress the mock-exam weeks.

Weeks 1 to 4: Foundation (Domains A, B, C)

- Week 1: Domain A and the first half of Domain B (B.1 to B.12).
- Week 2: Second half of Domain B (B.13 to B.24). Build a definitions deck as you go.
- Week 3: Domain C. Practice reading graphs and choosing measurement systems.
- Week 4: Take a timed practice set that reports results by domain. Record your accuracy for each domain; this is your baseline.

Weeks 5 to 8: Application (Domains D, E, F, G)

- Week 5: Domain D. Single-case designs, internal validity, and when each design fits.
- Week 6: Domain E. Read the Ethics Code for Behavior Analysts alongside the E tasks, not instead of them.
- Week 7: Domain F. Preference, descriptive, and functional assessment; interpreting the data.
- Week 8: Domain G. Reinforcement, prompting, shaping, chaining, generalization, punishment.

Weeks 9 to 11: Integration (Domains H, I) and full mocks

- Week 9: Domains H and I. Goal writing, intervention selection, procedural integrity, supervision.
- Weeks 10 and 11: One full-length timed mock each week (185 questions, four hours, no breaks beyond what the real exam allows). Spend the rest of the week reviewing every missed item against its task number.

Week 12: Review and rest

- Light review of your lowest two domains. No new material.
- Reread your own notes on the questions you missed twice.
- Take the day before the exam off.

A daily structure that holds up

Block	Activity	Time
Session 1	New content for the week's domain	45 to 60 min
Session 2	Practice questions, then read the rationale for every item, right or wrong	30 min
Session 3	Definitions and terminology review	15 to 20 min

What to track

Keep one page per domain. Each time you miss a question, write the task number, what the question was really testing, and the rule you should have applied. By week 9 those pages are your personalized review guide, and they are more useful than any generic summary.

Four signals tell you whether you are ready, and a good practice tool reports all four:

- Domain accuracy: consistently correct in every domain, not just the ones you like.
- Response time: answering within about 75 seconds without rushing.
- Consistency: the same result on a domain across several sessions, not one good day.
- Mock endurance: holding accuracy through the fourth hour of a full-length mock.

If you are short on time

Eight weeks: fold weeks 1 and 2 together and weeks 5 and 6 together, and keep both full mocks. Sixteen weeks: add a second pass through Domains B and G, and add a third full mock in week 14.

Concepts the exam keeps coming back to

Reinforcement and punishment (B.4, B.5)

Classify by two questions only: was a stimulus added or removed, and did the behavior increase or decrease over time? Whether the stimulus seems pleasant is irrelevant.

- Positive reinforcement: stimulus added, behavior increases. Praise after a completed task.
- Negative reinforcement: stimulus removed, behavior increases. Silencing an alarm by getting up.
- Positive punishment: stimulus added, behavior decreases. A reprimand following a response.
- Negative punishment: stimulus removed, behavior decreases. Loss of screen time after a rule violation.

Exam tip

The stem will describe the consequence. Look for the future-behavior clause ("and the behavior increased over the next week") before you name the process. No effect on behavior, no reinforcement or punishment.

Functions of behavior (F.5 to F.8)

Assessment questions want you to identify what the behavior produces, then choose an intervention that addresses that function. Four functions cover most scenarios:

- Automatic: the behavior itself produces the reinforcer, without another person.
- Escape or avoidance: the behavior removes or postpones a demand or aversive stimulus.
- Attention: the behavior produces social interaction.
- Access to tangibles: the behavior produces items or activities.

Know which assessment method the question describes: indirect (interviews, rating scales), descriptive (ABC recording in the natural setting), or functional analysis (conditions are manipulated). Only a functional analysis demonstrates a function; the others suggest one.

Ethics decision-making (Domain E)

Domain E is 22 questions, and most are scenarios with more than one defensible-sounding option. Work them in order:

- Name the Ethics Code standards involved. There are often two.
- Ask what protects the client first. Client welfare outranks convenience, cost, and the supervisor's preference.
- Check for a required step you would skip: consent, assent, documentation, consultation, referral.
- Consider cultural variables and your own biases (E.9 to E.11). The 6th Edition tests this directly.

- Choose the option that resolves the problem at the lowest appropriate level before escalating.

Measurement and graphs (Domain C)

Expect to match a measurement system to a behavior (count, rate, duration, latency, IRT, percent of opportunities, trials to criterion) and to read a graph for level, trend, and variability. Continuous measurement records every instance; discontinuous measurement (interval recording, momentary time sampling) samples and can over- or underestimate.

Supervision (Domain I)

At 11% of the exam, Domain I is larger than many candidates expect. The tasks ask you to treat supervision the way you treat any other behavior-change effort: assess the supervisee's skills (I.4), use empirically validated and culturally responsive training methods such as behavioral skills training (I.5), take a function-based approach to performance problems (I.6), and make data-based decisions about whether supervision is working (I.7).

A useful habit

When you miss a question, name the domain and the task, then say in one sentence why the correct answer is correct. If you cannot, the miss is a gap, not a slip. Put it on the domain page from Chapter 2.

Test-taking strategy

Before the exam

- Sleep seven to eight hours the night before. Cramming buys less than rest does.
- Eat a normal meal. The exam is four hours; plan for it.
- Arrive 30 minutes early and bring the identification your appointment confirmation requires.
- Know the testing center's break policy in advance so a break is a decision, not a surprise.

Pacing

185 questions in 240 minutes is about 78 seconds per question. Aim for a first pass at roughly 60 to 70 seconds each so you bank time for flagged items. Check the clock at question 50, 100, and 150; you should be near 65, 130, and 195 minutes.

- Flag anything that takes more than two minutes and move on.
- Answer every question on the first pass, even flagged ones. The score counts correct answers; a blank cannot be right.

Reading the question

- Read the whole stem. Identify the domain and, if you can, the task it is testing.
- Predict the answer before you look at the options.
- Eliminate options that are true statements but do not answer this question.
- Pick the most correct answer, not the first correct-sounding one.

Qualifier words

- "First," "best," and "most appropriate" ask you to rank, not to identify anything acceptable.
- "Except" and "not" reverse the logic. Reread the stem after you choose.
- Absolute language ("always," "never") in an option deserves a second look.

Managing anxiety in the room

- Slow breathing: in for four counts, hold for four, out for six. Three cycles.
- Feet on the floor, hands on the desk, eyes on one fixed point for ten seconds.
- Return to the process: read, predict, eliminate, choose. The process is what you practiced.

Mistakes to avoid

While studying

Instead of: Studying from materials that still use the 5th Edition Task List.

Instead of: Memorizing definitions without applying them.

Instead of: Reading rationales only for the questions you missed.

Instead of: Studying only the domains you enjoy.

Instead of: Taking untimed practice only.

Instead of: Studying up to the night before.

Do this: Check the edition first. Map everything you use to the 6th Edition outline.

Do this: After each definition, write a scenario and name the concept in it.

Do this: Read the rationale for every question. A lucky guess is a gap you have not seen yet.

Do this: Follow your domain accuracy, not your preferences. The weak domain is the assignment.

Do this: Take full-length timed mocks. Endurance through hour four is a skill you have to practice.

Do this: Take the last day off. Rest is part of the plan.

On exam day

Instead of: Changing an answer because of a feeling.

Instead of: Leaving questions blank.

Instead of: Spending five minutes on one hard item.

Instead of: Overthinking ethics scenarios.

Instead of: Skipping the break to save time.

Do this: Change an answer only when you can name the specific reason the new one is better.

Do this: Answer everything. Only correct answers count; there is no penalty for a wrong one.

Do this: Flag it, answer your best guess, and come back with the time you banked.

Do this: Apply the sequence from Chapter 3. The answer that protects the client and follows the Code is the answer.

Do this: Take it if you need it. Four hours of accuracy beats ten saved minutes.

Resources and a 30-day action plan

Official BACB documents (free at [bacb.com](https://www.bacb.com))

- BCBA Test Content Outline (6th ed.). The source for every domain and task in this guide.
- BCBA Handbook. Eligibility, application, scheduling, retake rules, and exam-day policies.
- Ethics Code for Behavior Analysts. Read it with the Domain E tasks beside it.

Textbooks

- Cooper, Heron, and Heward, Applied Behavior Analysis (3rd ed.). Covers Domains A through H.
- Bailey and Burch, Ethics for Behavior Analysts. Case-based practice for Domain E.

Practice

Behavior Study Tools, from Behavior School, has free BCBA practice questions written to the 6th Edition outline, with results by domain and a rationale on every answer. Use it for the week-4 baseline in Chapter 2.

Your first 30 days

This week

- ☐ Download the BCBA Test Content Outline (6th ed.) and read it once, start to finish.
- ☐ Check every study resource you own against the two edition tells in the introduction.
- ☐ Take a timed practice set, record your accuracy by domain, and put the 12-week schedule on a calendar.

Days 8 to 30

- ☐ Finish Domains A, B, and C (weeks 1 to 3 of the schedule).
- ☐ Start a domain page for every domain and log each missed question against its task number.
- ☐ Take your week-4 timed set and compare it with the baseline.
- ☐ Confirm your eligibility status and schedule the exam date so the plan has an end.

The guide tells you what to study. Practice tells you where you stand.

Start with the free 6th Edition practice set: see the missed domain, review the rationale, and choose the next study task.

study.behaviorschool.com/free-practice

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Domain names, task counts, question counts, and percentages in Chapter 1 are reproduced from the BCBA Test Content Outline (6th ed.), updated September 2024. Verify against the current document at [bacb.com](https://www.bacb.com) before your exam; the BACB may revise it.

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